

The EU's summer homework

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GABRIEL GAVIN GOOD MOR

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GOOD MORNING — It's Gabriel Gavin with you on the International Day of Friendship. As Brussels empties out, remember you'll always have a friend in Playbook!

In today's Playbook:

- Why are officials in the Berlaymont still at work?
- Stronger, smarter, more secure: The Commission's GPT@EC gets a makeover.
- Faces in the crowd: Ursula von der Leyen, Ed Miliband, Thorsten Frei, Jean Quatremer, Arianna Podesta, Charlie Chaplin, Glen Hansard, Sigrid Friis, Nikos Christodoulides, Raffaele Fitto, Ingmar Bergman, Sébastien Lecornu, Anthony Fauci and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Sarah explore the EU's new powers to police the world's most powerful AI systems.

DRIVING THE DAY

SUMMER SPRINT: With much of Brussels shutting down for August, a small group of European Commission officials is working through the summer to give Ursula von der Leyen enough to announce in her Sept. 16 State of the European Union speech.

Seven-week deadline: The unfinished business includes limits on children's social media use, plans targeting cyberattacks and economic coercion, action on Chinese trade practices, early benefits for EU candidate countries and the bloc's proposed €2 trillion budget, five officials involved in preparing the speech told Playbook.

What's at stake: Von der Leyen needs to show that her second Commission is getting things done while keeping her fragile parliamentary majority together and responding to populist parties accusing Brussels of ignoring voters. Renew Europe lawmaker Sigrid Friis said SOTEU must show pro-European parties can "drive Europe forward" and that von der Leyen will work with them rather than "give in to populists or the loudest voices on the extremes."

Great expectations: Von der Leyen “considers SOTEU to be of great importance” as a “decisive annual moment” for her as a leader, and it is usual for it to involve “months of preparations” to help “bring together the members of Parliament and the Commission,” Commission spokesperson Arianna Podesta told Playbook.

Age limits: The Commission president has already backed restrictions on children’s access to social media. Officials are still debating which platforms would be covered and what age limit should apply. She is expected to raise the issue in her address, with detailed proposals later.

Under attack: The EU executive is also finishing its new European Security Strategy, meant to protect the bloc from cyberattacks, sabotage and economic coercion. Much of it has been written for months, officials said, but publication was held back until after the summer break.

Budget fight: Ahead of the Oct. 15-16 EU leaders’ summit, the Commission is preparing to defend its proposed seven-year budget — its €2 trillion size, its spending choices and the new taxes Brussels wants to impose to help pay for it.

Pre-membership perks: Leaders are also expected to discuss benefits for candidate countries before they formally join — proposals being drawn up by Commission officials. The aim is to keep candidates moving toward membership while reassuring skeptical governments and voters that new members won’t be admitted before they’re ready.

China plans: Officials are also using the summer to prepare measures against Chinese trade practices, including a new tool giving Brussels more scope to retaliate. The plans are due in October, although von der Leyen may sketch them out in her speech.

Time pressures: It’s true the commission president has three years left to secure her legacy. But her room to act could shrink if pro-EU parties lose ground in France, Poland or Spain in 2027.

BIG AND BREAKING

LAST NIGHT IN THE MIDDLE EAST: The U.S. launched fresh strikes on Iran in response to an attack on its forces Tuesday, my stateside colleagues report .

PiS PUNCH-UP: Poland’s main opposition party is shifting to the right ahead of next year’s parliamentary election, with an internal ideological fight underway over its EU stance, Bartosz Brzeziński writes.

WORLD CUP BACKLASH: European football officials are considering backing Qatari sports executive and PSG boss Nasser al-Khelaifi as a challenger to Gianni Infantino in next year’s election for FIFA’s top job, POLITICO reports .

PREMIUM PROBLEMS: As wildfires rage in France and Spain, another casualty of the increasingly frequent disasters hitting the continent is appearing — parts of Europe could soon be uninsurable. Marianne Gros, Giorgio Leali and Aude Le Gentil have the story .

DELHI DEALINGS: Russia is importing European technology that could be used to keep its war machine operational via supply chains that run through India , data seen by Graham Lanktree shows.

AI OVERHAUL

INSTALLING UPDATE: The European Commission has overhauled GPT@EC, the in-house AI platform used by officials, the company behind its infrastructure told my colleague Pieter Haeck. It's the third update to the AI tool.

What's new: Staff will be able to search more internal material through links to Microsoft Office 365 and Outlook, use a secure "deep research" function to search the web and speak to the platform through a voice interface, according to the German AI company Deepset.

AI woes: The upgrade comes as EU institutions try to prevent officials and lawmakers from feeding sensitive material into public chatbots, with the European Parliament building its own platform after concerns about AI-drafted speeches, questions and amendments.

4 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

QUATRE-MOVER: One of Brussels' best-known journalists, Jean Quatremer, is leaving his role at France's Libération newspaper after more than 40 years, citing ideological differences with Libé. He'll join weekly magazine Marianne as a columnist.

MERZ'S MAN: Germany's governing CDU/CSU bloc elected lawmaker Thorsten Frei as its parliamentary leader in a vote yesterday .

LET'S PUT OUR EDS TOGETHER: British Foreign Secretary Ed Miliband is in pole position to lead the U.K.'s efforts to reset relations with Brussels , as the new government eyes an all-important post-Brexit summit later this year.

EXPULSION ROW: France has moved to expel Russian TV star Xenia Fedorova — but the media companies that employ her say it's a "serious attack on freedom of expression. "

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked what you'd like Ursula von derLeyen to mention in her State of the European Union speech. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny, with a chance of afternoon showers. High of 28C.

FOR THOSE LEFT BEHIND: The EU quarter might have largely emptied out for the summer, but that's nothing compared to the ghost town it will become from Aug. 1. But fear not: there's no shortage of things to do.

Sun Screens: Indie cinema Palace is hosting its flagship summer schedule, including a mix of restored classics from Ingmar Bergman and Charlie Chaplin, as well as arthouse and animation, in a mix of English, French and Dutch, with subtitles. The theaters are air-conditioned, if you're looking to escape the heat.

Forest Sounds Festival: From Aug. 28, Brussels' Forest Abbey transforms into an outdoor music venue for two days of live performances from artists including electro-Congolese group Kin'Gongolo Kiniata and dream pop trio Lude & les métamorphoses. Tickets are on sale from as little as €6.

Blessed be the frites: Tiny specialty museum Home Frit' Home is opening its doors for free open days on Aug. 1-2, with an exhibition dedicated to the intersection between Belgian fries and the Catholic faith.

Practice French in the Park: Conte en Balade hosts guided tours with storytellers in Brussels' green spaces throughout August, with tickets available online .

Classissimo: The Théâtre Royal du Parc will host a series of seven concerts from Aug. 5-11, ranging from French Baroque to Mozart and Tango music. The full program is here .

Pompompom: Brussels' cider festival is back for two days from Aug. 29, promising outdoor food, music and apple juice of the fermented variety.

Brussels Games Festival: Why be bored when you could bring out a board? This massive convention brings together almost 300 stalls with board-game makers, card enthusiasts and tournaments, from Aug. 28 .

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The CDU/CSU strongly endorsed Thorsten Frei — but it was a vote of confidence for the new parliamentary leader, not Friedrich Merz.

London: Andy Burnham will make his first major funding announcement this morning, promising £8.4 billion for the next phase of the Dreadnought-class submarine program.

Paris: Sébastien Lecornu has postponed his vacation to prioritize the megafire crisis after accusations the government was caught unprepared.

Washington PM: The much-anticipated Senate committee clash between Rand Paul and former Covid-19 czar Anthony Fauci fizzled out when Fauci refused to answer questions.

AGENDA

— Youth Commissioner Glenn Micallef speaks virtually at the high level conference “Listening to Children and Young People — Challenges in Challenging Settings,” in Dublin.

— European Commission Executive Vice President and the EU's envoy for Cyprus Raffaele Fitto will travel to Cyprus ahead of meetings Friday with Cypriot President Nikos Christodoulides and the Turkish Cypriot leader Tufan Erhürman.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Ville Niinistö; former MEPs Dorien Rookmaker and Catherine Stihler; European Commissioner Glenn Micallef; Scalian's Anthony Papadimitriou; Pierre Barthélemy, formerly of CEFIC.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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